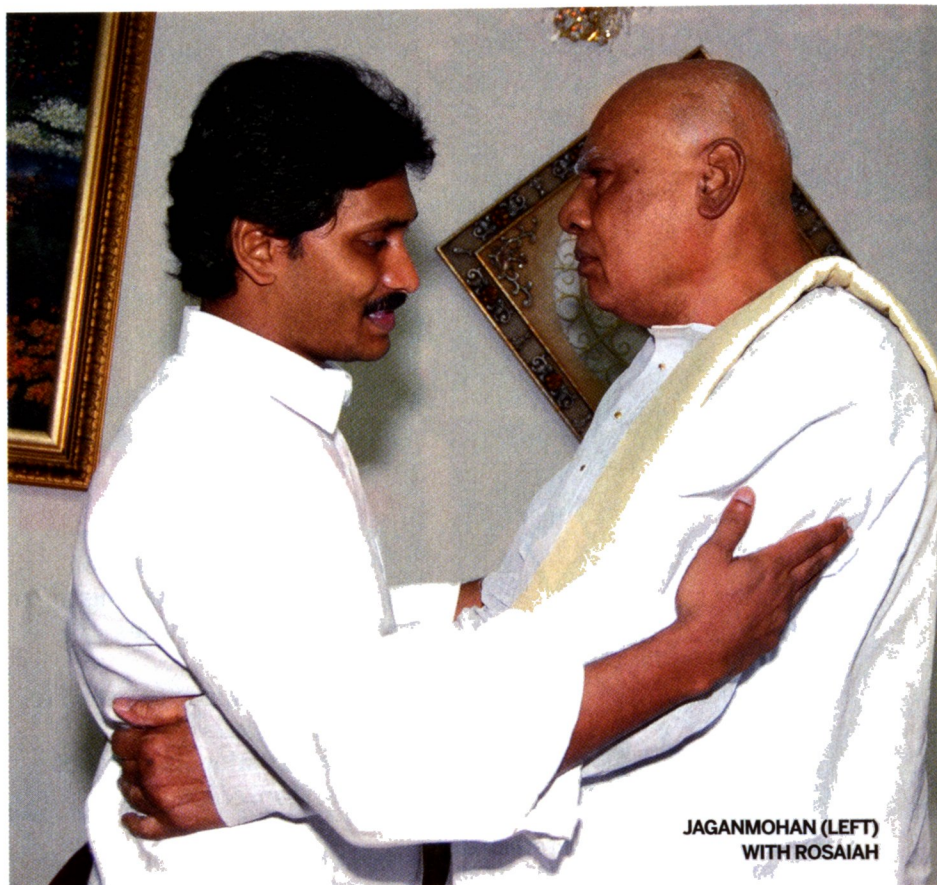


By Amarnath K. Menon

You can reach Ponnala Lakshmaiah on +919848782004. He is a US-educated engineer-turned-politician and currently the Andhra Pradesh minister for major irrigation. His cell phone ringtone is a lively folk number that extols YS Palana (Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy's governance) and his dreams for the state, and often he lets it ring for a while before he answers the phone. There are many YSR diehards like Lakshmaiah in the 33-member team of Chief Minister Konijeti Rosaiah as well as among Congress MLAs and MLCs and in the Congress party across the state. Seven months after his death in a chopper crash, YSR lives on.

Y.S. Jaganmohan Reddy, the late chief minister's son and a Congress MP who made an unsuccessful bid to succeed his father, has launched the Odarpu (consoling) Yatra, calling on the families of people who died or committed suicide in the wake of YSR's tragic death. As the first leg of his tour concluded last week, it was clear that Jaganmohan, like his father, is a popular draw. While arranging to pay the token compensation to the families, Jaganmohan is making sure that the YSR vision for Andhra Pradesh is pursued at a steady pace to serve as a springboard for him to emerge as a pan-Andhra leader.

The initial signs are encouraging. In the first leg of the Odarpu Yatra, he could draw a positive response even in Khammam district of the Telangana region, much to the consternation of the separatist Telangana Rashtra Samiti. Jaganmohan and several vocal supporters of the former chief minister have accused his successor Rosaiah of stalling YSR schemes. "We are facing some financial problems but have not discontinued any of the initiatives. I will soldier on as we are pledged to complete all welfare measures that YSR launched," says Rosaiah, who has embarked on his Prajapatham (mass contact) journey from Katarivaripalem village near



JAGANMOHAN (LEFT)
WITH ROSAIAH

Pruning a LEGACY

On a belt tightening mission, cash-strapped Andhra Pradesh is trimming many of YSR's populist schemes

Vetapalem in his native Prakasam district. Prajapatham, the brainchild of YSR, is a special platform that enables elected representatives to be present among the people and help them when they face problems. The month-long programme which began on April 19 is to culminate with the celebration of rededication day, marking the completion of one year of

the Congress Government in power. But with the cutbacks on popular programmes, this round of Prajapatham, the first without YSR, is distinct from the earlier four in emphasising that governance remains an inclusive approach, financial constraints notwithstanding. In fact, about 100,600 acres are being distributed to 69,506 poor